

Healthtech, for that matter, is the obvious example of one such sector, given the times we live in. While the entire world is reeling under a pandemic, the importance of IoT-enabled devices in the medical sector has been proven to be the biggest at the moment. Moreover, given the jarring discrepancy in the doctor to patient ratio in India, there is an urgent need to be able to provide care for multiple patients simultaneously to counteract the lack of medical resources. Innovative IoT solutions that help diminish this gap are definitely the need of the hour.

Logistics is another burgeoning area where IoT solutions have made the job much easier, especially in Tier 1 and Tier 2 cities. New IoT solutions that make logistics easier and simpler are coming up every day, which proves how big the opportunity is, more so in a country as big as India.

Having said that, one truly remarkable aspect where IoT has become a game-changer is the agricultural sector. India is a largely agrarian country, and it is a no-brainer how big of an opportunity IoT companies are targeting to solve the problems related to the same.

Making IoT startups successful

While the opportunities are countless, the startup game is still a tough nut to crack for many. In an age of new startups, making one successful remains a challenge.

“IoT startups in India have been thriving in diverse spaces. The applications are not just limited to the standard home care or transportation solutions but also expanding towards other sectors where one could not have anticipated IoT to play any role,” says Porwal.

First, to make sure a startup is not just like any other, it is essential to validate the existence of a problem statement that is troubling a large enough user base.

“You really need to have some customer sponsors and map them to what your idea is. If they are willing to buy a solution based on that idea, you can be assured that it is going to be viable,” advises Sanket Bandyopadhyay, Co-Founder & Vice President, Daikoku Innovations.

From an investor’s perspective, Suresh Narasimha, Managing Partner, PESU Venture Labs (PVL) and

Cofounder of CoCreate Ventures, notes that a solution that is meant for a niche market has a hard time gathering funds. This provides us with this formula—a viable solution for a scalable market.

While it looks good on paper, building a startup is seldom so smooth. With the reliance of IoT heavily on hardware, reaching the zenith takes a lot more effort than a solely software startup. A hardware startup, whether IoT-enabled or not, needs a significant level of engineering expertise at the first stage itself. The wider the expertise, the larger the profit. However, getting a diverse range of experts is not an easy job for any new entrepreneur.

One must realise that IoT is not a one-man show. The hardware is just as important as the software. Thus, having a solution that takes care of every possible aspect can become a more lucrative option for a budding entrepreneur. Figuring out what the company can do best and investing more energy on those fronts can be a way of making sure you have one strong core element as part of the solution.

“Certain bits give you good returns in terms of focusing and channelising your energy in one direction. The more important thing is that there should be some sustainability plan in case one front fails,” advises Porwal.

Going global

“India has a superset of problems I would say, so if you solve problems in India then the subset of Indian problems will flow into the global market,” says Bandyopadhyay.

The target of IoT is to solve daily-life problems and make the user functionality easier. In a country like India, where the variety of problems are more, it helps to note that when looked from a global perspective in all its uniqueness, similar problems exist all over the world. So, the genesis of thinking global is around looking at the problem one is solving.

With respect to the process of figuring out the problem in common that IoT is looking to solve, extensive research and hit-and-trials are done. This makes sure that the design of the solution solves the pain point not just for Indian consumers but also globally. “India is a very cost-sensitive

market, so if you can test your product in India and it works, you can actually sell it outside in regions like Europe and Asia,” informs Bandyopadhyay.

Carving a global map for an IoT startup is definitely not going to be a piece of cake. But the advantage here is that most IoT startups run on the software as a service (SaaS) model, which makes it much more scalable in the international markets. Also, making sure that the product or solution is possible in all reputable markets is a way of figuring out if there is a chance of it becoming a hit internationally.

“One thing that I think that startups could start thinking about immediately is to go by the lean principles,” advises Bandyopadhyay. “Once the idea of standardisation comes into the picture, IoT plays a big role there. For example, if you can standardise things in a PLC manufacturing unit in India, you can take that to other bigger units in the West.”

With Industry 4.0 taking the world by storm, focusing on optimisation and standardisation of processes is an ideal way to go about. Designing a solution that works in India and also functions with the same efficiency in other markets can be tedious. Because there are way too many factors that need to fall in place for a product to fit all possible markets. The buyer’s persona changes from one country to another; the priorities of a customer in the UK may be quite different from that of a customer in India.

“Before we customise our plans for different countries, we should first customise the plan for the product that we are building on,” advises Narasimha. In order to localise a product or platform for the country in which it will operate, it is essential to gather a larger user base, something that is extremely crucial for an organisation spreading its wings to other countries.

The additional components of IoT have complications, which include managing the hardware, the supply chain logistics, certifications, shipments, and the final deployment despite its scalability option. Moreover, the intensive data collection by IoT platforms makes it susceptible to exhaustive scrutiny by government authorities that wish to prevent any instance of data and privacy breach.

On the contrary, Narasimha advises that a startup should rather rack their